

Russia and NATO Enlargement

How did the 2002 Prague Summit Increase Russian Agression Towards Old NATO Countries, the Baltics, and Eastern European Countries?

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Abstract

This paper examines whether NATO enlargement to the Baltic states triggered escalatory behavior from Russia. Using GDELT event data from 2000 to 2008 and a difference-in-differences design, I analyze changes in Russia's verbal and material conflict toward Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania compared to a control group of non-enlarged states. Event-study estimates indicate flat pre-treatment trends and a modest increase in verbal conflict beginning in 2003, following the 2002 Prague Summit invitation to join NATO. This rhetorical escalation persists through 2006 but does not intensify following formal accession in 2004. Material conflict exhibits smaller and less consistent increases during the same period. Overall, the findings suggest that NATO enlargement generated short-term rhetorical signaling rather than sustained material confrontation, supporting theories of strategic signaling over claims of immediate security backlash.

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Introduction

The Research Question

After the Cold War, NATO expanded eastward and officially invited the Baltic states to join their organization during the Prague Summit in November of 2002, bringing the alliance directly to Russia's border and intensifying long-standing security tensions between Moscow and the West. Though other scholars have acknowledge hostility present within NATO and Russia during this time, it has never fully been measured with the unique comparison of Russia's actions between Baltic and non-Baltic states post-Prague Summit. To fill this gap, I utilize a differences in differences model with data from GDELT, a dataset of articles, newspapers, factors related to political communication, which will be critical to asses Russia's differences in behavior towards other countries.

Historical Context

After the Cold War, NATO expanded eastward. The largest group of new countries officially joined in 2004, after the Prague Summit when seven countries received an invite: Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Slovakia, Romania, Bulgaria, and Slovenia. For many of these countries, membership in NATO meant protection against future Russian pressure. Yet, from Moscow's perspective, not all of these states looked the same.

The Baltic states were former Soviet republics, not just former Warsaw Pact members. Estonia and Latvia each had large Russian-speaking minorities, roughly 25–30 percent of their populations, many of whom faced restrictive citizenship and language laws after independence. Russian leaders claimed a responsibility to defend these communities. Geography made the situation even more sensitive. Tallinn, the capital of Estonia, is less than 200 miles from St. Petersburg, Russia's second-largest city. Lithuania borders Kaliningrad, where Russia's Baltic Fleet is stationed. When the Baltic countries joined NATO, the alliance moved directly onto Russia's frontier.

First, the Baltic states had a common historical past with Russia, being former Soviet republics. Thus, Moscow viewed them as former members of the Russian and Soviet state itself. Losing these states when they joined NATO was not just a geopolitical setback, but a symbolic loss of the empire itself. When the Soviet Union collapsed, Russia struggled with its post-imperial identity. Not only had they lost a significant part of the Union, but they had lost a large part of their presence in Europe as well,

leading to an additional loss in European identity. Since the Baltics represented such a significant part of Russia's past, NATO membership meant that the historically important territory once governed by Moscow was now under a military alliance initially created to counter Moscow. Therefore, the very idea of the Baltic countries joining NATO was a visible confirmation that Russia's imperial sphere was gone. This emotional and symbolic perspective increases the likelihood of hostility because this territory once belonged to the Soviet Union.

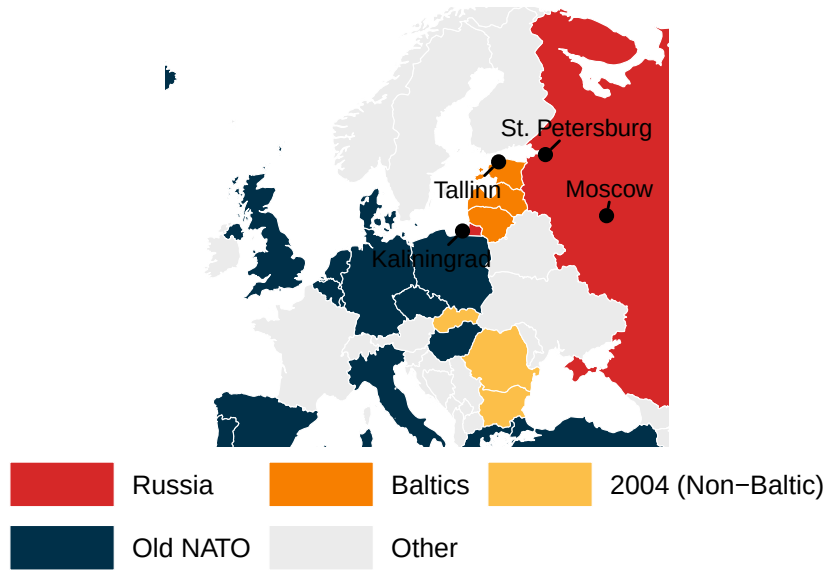
Additionally, because the Baltic countries were part of the Soviet Union, they have a large population of Russian speakers. After claiming independence, citizenship and language policies limited the political representation of some of these residents. Moscow framed this action as discrimination against its people, claiming a right to defend compatriots abroad. The historical past combined with the Russian-speaking population created a justification tool that Moscow could use to criticize Baltic governments.

Proximity is also an important factor towards understanding Moscow's point of view. The capital of Estonia, Tallinn is less than 200 miles from St. Petersburg and Lithuania borders Kaliningrad, where the Russian Baltic Fleet is stationed. The map below indicates the proximity. In terms of deterrence, this increased the stakes that NATO would invite the Baltic states as a strategic advantages over Russia, as Moscow would care about what happens to the Baltics more than Romania, Bulgaria or Slovakia. Thus, this difference can generate two hypotheses:

1. If Russia reacts more strongly to the Baltics than to other 2004 entrants, then historical ties truly matter to the discussion.
2. If it reacts similarly to both groups, then enlargement itself is likely the key aggravator.

Study Region

Baltics (treated), pre-2004 NATO (control), 2004 non-E



Since the Baltic states are considered former Soviet imperial territory, from Moscow's perspective, their loss is seen as a threat. As seen with historical examples, such as Nazi Germany, buffer zones in Eastern Europe has served as strategic depth. Hence, when these territories exit Russia's sphere in the Cold War, joining NATO in 2004, and host Western military infrastructure, Russia interprets this as loss of defensive depth, and potentially, a threat. Secondly, the close geographic proximity gives the West the ability to place missiles or other weapons, amplifying perceived threats. Lastly, the presence of Russian minorities in the Baltics creates a civilization link, responsibility claim, and a narrative of protection, as discussed earlier. Therefore, when these minorities are now under NATO, Russia now faces cultural erosion, westernization, and the suppression of Russian identity, becoming a cultural and security overlap. Therefore, in regions characterized by shared imperial history, geographic proximity, and co-ethnic populations, NATO expansion is likely to be perceived by Russia not merely as alliance enlargement but as a compound security and civilizational threat.

Romania, Bulgaria, and Slovakia also entered NATO in 2004, but they were different cases as none were former Soviet republics. None bordered Russia and none contained large Russian-speaking populations that Moscow claimed to protect. For Russia, their membership was less symbolically and strategically threatening. This difference creates the central comparison in this paper: if NATO expansion provoked Russia, we should expect a stronger reaction toward the Baltic states than toward

the other 2004 entrants.

Literature Review

NATO Expansion and Security Competition

Debate over NATO enlargement centers on whether eastward expansion is stabilizing or destabilizing European security. Realist scholars often argue that great powers are structurally subject to resist alliance encroachment near their borders. A prominent figure in this regard is John J. Mearsheimer when he argues that NATO expansion into Eastern Europe significantly altered regional balance of power and threatened the Russian sphere of influence. In his analysis of the Ukraine crisis, [Mearsheimer, 2014] argues that Western liberal expansionism provoked predictable backlash by ignoring core principles of great power politics.

Yet, historical accounts complicate this structural explanation. For example, Mary Elise Sarotte [Sarotte, 2021], in “Not One Inch,” demonstrates that NATO enlargement was not inevitable but emerged through contingent diplomatic decisions and ambiguous Western assurances in the 1990s. More specifically, in 1990, President Bush had promised not to expand NATO eastward if a reunified Germany was to be under NATO’s protection. However, this promise was not kept, as the Prague Summit invited nations eastward to join NATO. Hence, the war on Ukraine could be seen as a predictable retaliation in response to this broken promise. Similarly, Ronald D. Asmus [Asmus, 2002] tells the story of expansion as a deliberate effort to remake NATO for a post-Cold War era, placing Central and Eastern Europe within Western institutions. Such accounts suggest that Russia’s reaction may reflect not just simply structural insecurity but also perceived diplomatic exclusion and betrayal.

Combined, these works highlight that NATO enlargement reshaped both the strategic and political landscape of post-Cold War Europe, creating the conditions under which Russia might signal opposition, change its behavior, or withdraw cooperation.

The Baltics: History, Proximity, and Civilizational Identity

The Baltic states represent a particularly sensitive case in the enlargement debate. As former Soviet republics located directly on Russia’s border, their choice to join NATO combined geographic proximity with historical entanglement. Mark Kramer [Kramer, 2002] argued that Baltic enlargement posed

unique challenges for NATO-Russian relations because of Russia’s security concerns and the region’s symbolic importance.

Other than military geography, identity politics plays a critical role. Dmitri Trenin [Trenin, 2002] characterizes Russia as a state situated between geopolitics and a civilizational identity, arguing that its foreign policy cannot be understood solely in material terms. The presence of Russian-speaking minorities in Estonia and Latvia only deepens this connection. Ammon Cheskin and Angela Kachuyevski [Cheskin and Kachuyevski, 2019] show that Russian-speaking minorities in former Soviet republics occupy contested political and identity positions, often serving as focal points for the transnational narratives of protection and belonging.

These historical, geographic, and demographic factors generate the threat perception that NATO expansion into the Baltics may be interpreted as both military encroachment and the erosion of Russia’s cultural and civilizational sphere.

Signaling, Coercion, and Limited Escalation

If the expansion of NATO creates perceptions of threats, the question remains: how should Russia respond? Classic signaling theory can provide an answer. Thomas C. Schelling [Schelling, 1966] explains that states often use threats, demonstrations, and limited actions to influence adversaries without triggering uncontrolled escalation. James J. Fearon [Fearon, 1997] builds on this logic, distinguishing “tying hands” and “sinking costs” as mechanisms through which states can credibly resolve signals.

Applied to the expansion of NATO, these frameworks suggest that Russia may increase rhetorical hostility or symbolic confrontation to signal dissatisfaction while avoiding potentially costly military escalation. Verbal conflict then serves as a low-risk signaling mechanism, especially when direct confrontation risks invoking NATO’s collective defense commitments under Article 5.

Alliances and the Constraint of Article 5

The deterrent power of alliances further shapes expected behavior. Brett Ashley Leeds [Leeds, 2003] found that military alliances significantly reduces the likelihood of aggression towards member states. Thus, NATO’s Article 5 commitment imposes significant constraints on Russia’s potential use of force against newly admitted members, in this case, the Baltic states.

Under this logic, material conflict should remain limited following Baltic accession, even if tensions rise. Instead, if Russia were to escalate, Moscow may shift its strategy towards tactics that do not involve use of military like diplomatic pressure, economic leverage, or rhetorical confrontation. This is consistent with signaling theory and alliance deterrence findings.

Interactions: Event Data and Behavioral Change

To evaluate these theoretical expectations, this study relies on event data cataloging Russia's interactions with NATO member states. The Global Database of Events, Language, and Tone (GDEL) provides systematic coding of verbal and material interactions across countries over time. As described by Kalev Leetaru and Philip A. Schrodt [[Leetaru and Schrodt, 2013](#)], GDEL allows for a fine-grained, in-depth analysis of conflict, cooperation, and tone across international dyads.

By differentiating between verbal conflict, material conflict, and cooperation events this study is able to test whether NATO expansion altered the composition of volume of Russia's interactions. Specifically, it assesses whether expansion produced:

1. increased verbal signaling
2. stable material conflict due to deterrence, or
3. broader relational withdrawal

Conclusion of the Literature

The existing literature suggests three competing and non-mutually exclusive expectations. Realist and historical perspectives predict increased tension following NATO expansion. Identity-based analyses emphasize the particular sensitivity of the Baltic case, as these states were once part of the Soviet Union. Signaling and alliance theory imply that escalation may be more rhetorical than military due to strong deterrent constraints like Article 5 of NATO. The present study combines these viewpoints by empirically evaluating how Russia's verbal, material, and cooperative interactions changed following NATO's 2002 enlargement announcement.

Theory and Hypothesis

If Russia sends verbal threats, then we should see a spike in `verbal_conflict`, and `verbal_share`.

If Russia avoids military conflict because NATO Article 5 would mean global war, then material_conflict and material_share should remain stable.

If Russia pulls back from the relationship entirely, then verbal_share, verbal_conflict, material_conflict and material_share will decrease.

The Data

What is the Data?

The data in this study come from the Global Database of Events, Language and Tone (GDEL). GDEL is a very large dataset that automatically collects data from news around the world and codes it into structured “events.” For example, if a Russian official were to criticize Estonia, it is coded as a verbal conflict. Each event includes the country acting, the country targeted, the type of interaction that occurred, and the date in which the event occurred. For this project, each row in the dataset represents Russia’s behavior towards one specific country in a specific month. Figures 2 and 3 show an example of this data:

Table 1: Data Structure Overview

Description	Explanation
Data Source	GDEL event data (news-coded international interactions)
Unit of Analysis	Country-month observation
Actor	Russia
Target	target_country variable
Time Unit	year_month variable

Table 2: Example Country-Month Observations

target_country	year_month	verbal_conflict	material_conflict
ALB	2000-01-01	1	4
ALB	2000-02-01	16	6
ALB	2000-03-01	13	32

target_country	year_month	verbal_conflict	material_conflict
ALB	2000-04-01	10	5
ALB	2000-05-01	1	21
ALB	2000-06-01	11	10
ALB	2000-07-01	4	4
ALB	2000-08-01	0	1

Since the study aims to identify how Russia treated the Baltics compared to other countries invited to join NATO in 2002, these states (Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania), represent the Treated Group. The control group is represented by countries that had already been part of NATO prior to the Prague Summit. These include countries like the United States, France, and the United Kingdom. Additionally, a Placebo group exists. Romania, Bulgaria, and Slovakia were also invited during the Prague Summit and officially joined NATO in 2004 with the Baltic states. This group exists to test whether Russia reacted to NATO expansion in general, or specifically in relation to the Baltics.

For the differences in differences model, the before and after comparison will be the Prague Summit in 2002 when NATO invited the countries to join. Before 2002, the data will examine how often Russia engaged in conflictual behavior toward these countries, and post-2002 it will show whether the behavior increased, decreased, or stayed the same.

Differences in Differences Regression

The differences in differences model is a two-way fixed effects difference-in-differences model at the country-year level, shown by the following formula:

$$VerbalShare_{it} = \alpha + \beta(Baltic_i \times Post2002_t) + \gamma_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{it}$$

The dependent variable is the share of Russia's interactions classified as verbal conflict toward country in year t. The key independent variable is an interaction between an indicator for Baltic states and a post-treatment period indicator. Country fixed effects account for time-invariant differences across states, while year fixed effects capture common shocks and global temporal trends. Standard

errors are clustered at the country level.

The variable 'baltic:postTRUE' has been removed because of collinearity (see \$collin.var).

OLS estimation, Dep. Var.: verbal_conflict

Observations: 2,376

Fixed-effects: target_country: 22, year_month: 108

Standard-errors: Clustered (target_country)

	Estimate	Std. Error	t value	Pr(> t)
baltic:postFALSE	6.68303	6.56955	1.01727	0.3206

... 1 variable was removed because of collinearity (baltic:postTRUE)

Signif. codes: 0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

RMSE: 51.7 Adj. R2: 0.363118

Within R2: 4.309e-4

The variable 'baltic:postTRUE' has been removed because of collinearity (see \$collin.var).

OLS estimation, Dep. Var.: material_conflict

Observations: 2,376

Fixed-effects: target_country: 22, year_month: 108

Standard-errors: Clustered (target_country)

	Estimate	Std. Error	t value	Pr(> t)
baltic:postFALSE	1.49375	4.2314	0.353016	0.72759

... 1 variable was removed because of collinearity (baltic:postTRUE)

Signif. codes: 0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

RMSE: 36.4 Adj. R2: 0.259914

Within R2: 4.355e-5

The variable 'baltic:postTRUE' has been removed because of collinearity (see \$collin.var).

```

OLS estimation, Dep. Var.: cooperation_events
Observations: 2,376
Fixed-effects: target_country: 22, year_month: 108
Standard-errors: Clustered (target_country)

              Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
baltic:postFALSE 35.1501    17.6556 1.99087 0.059666 .
... 1 variable was removed because of collinearity (baltic:postTRUE)
---
Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1
RMSE: 148.3      Adj. R2: 0.57816
                Within R2: 0.001448

The variable 'baltic:postTRUE' has been removed because of collinearity (see
$collin.var).

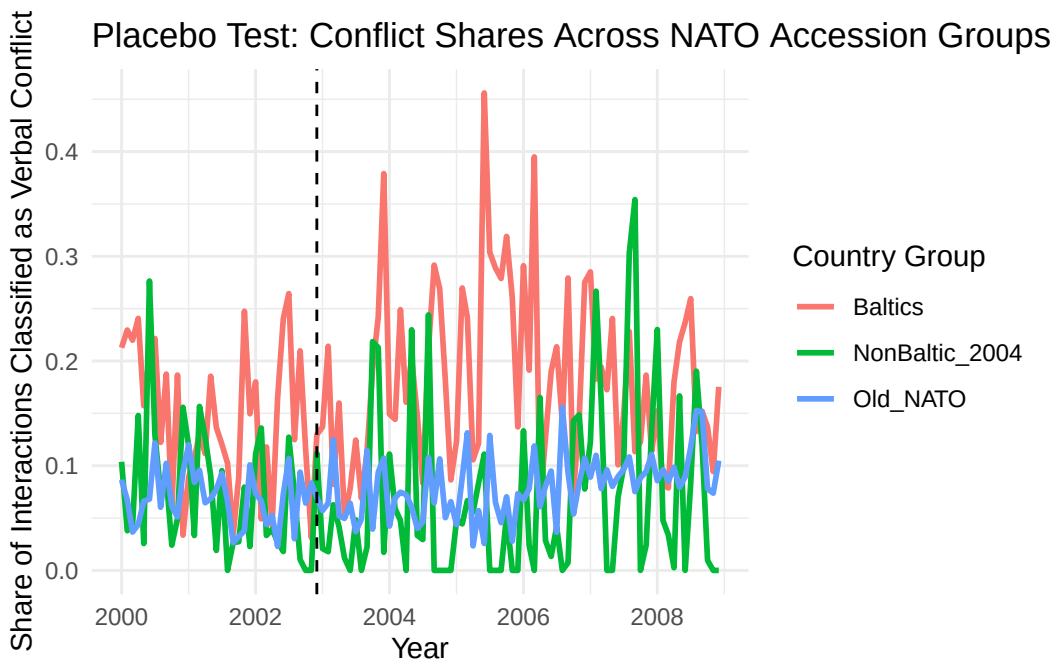
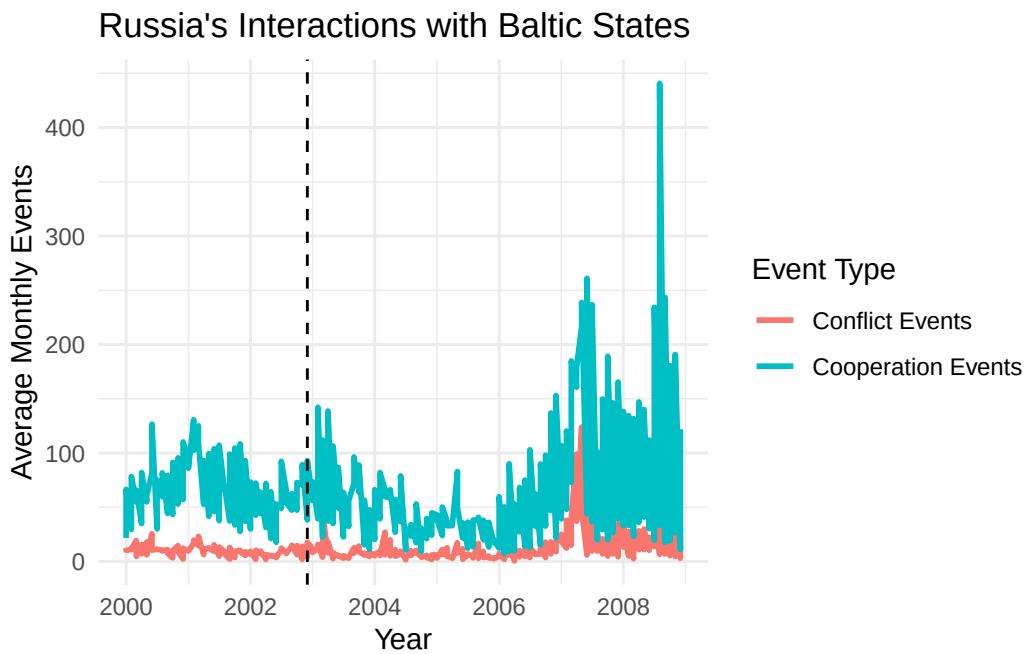
OLS estimation, Dep. Var.: total_events
Observations: 2,376
Fixed-effects: target_country: 22, year_month: 108
Standard-errors: Clustered (target_country)

              Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
baltic:postFALSE 43.3269    27.7387 1.56197 0.13324
... 1 variable was removed because of collinearity (baltic:postTRUE)
---
Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1
RMSE: 227.4      Adj. R2: 0.513112
                Within R2: 9.358e-4

NOTE: 186 observations removed because of NA values (LHS: 186).
The variable 'baltic:postTRUE' has been removed because of collinearity (see
$collin.var).

Warning: Using `size` aesthetic for lines was deprecated in ggplot2 3.4.0.
i Please use `linewidth` instead.

```



(viridis color scheme and use a rolling average [3-6 months])

OLS estimation, Dep. Var.: verbal_mean

Observations: 306

Fixed-effects: target_country: 34, year: 9

Standard-errors: Clustered (target_country)

```
Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
baltic:post2002 0.026946 0.015179 1.77516 0.085097 .
... 2 variables were removed because of collinearity (baltic and
post2002)
---
Signif. codes: 0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1
RMSE: 0.047634 Adj. R2: 0.374815
Within R2: 0.005688
```

The interaction term between Baltic countries and the post-2002 period is positive and statistically significant at the 10 percent level ($\beta = 0.027$, $SE = 0.015$, $p = 0.085$), suggesting that Russia's share of verbal conflict toward the Baltics increased by approximately 2.7 percentage points following the Prague Summit announcement relative to other states. While not significant at conventional 5 percent levels, the magnitude and direction are consistent with a modest anticipatory signaling effect.

OLS estimation, Dep. Var.: verbal_mean

Observations: 306

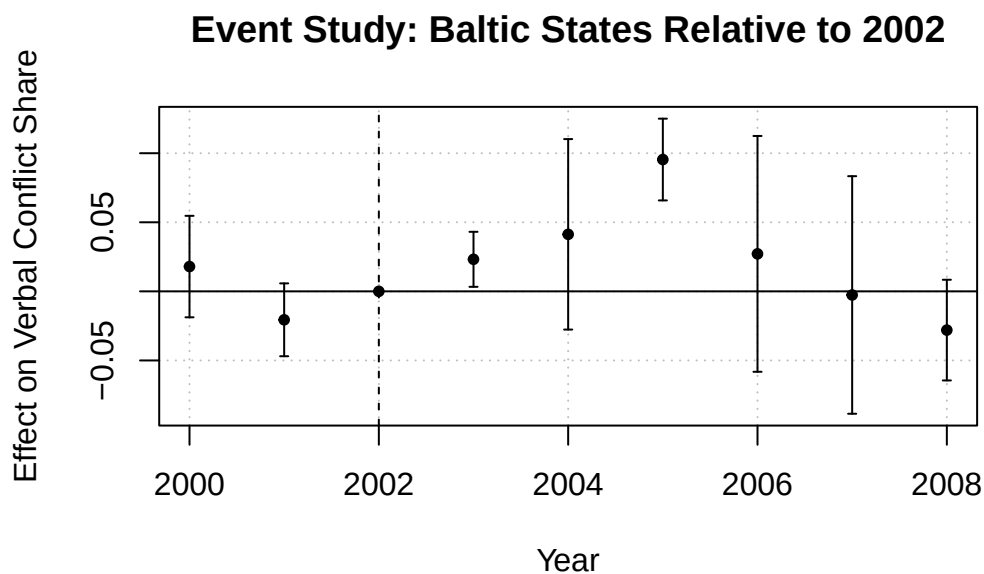
Fixed-effects: target_country: 34, year: 9

Standard-errors: Clustered (target_country)

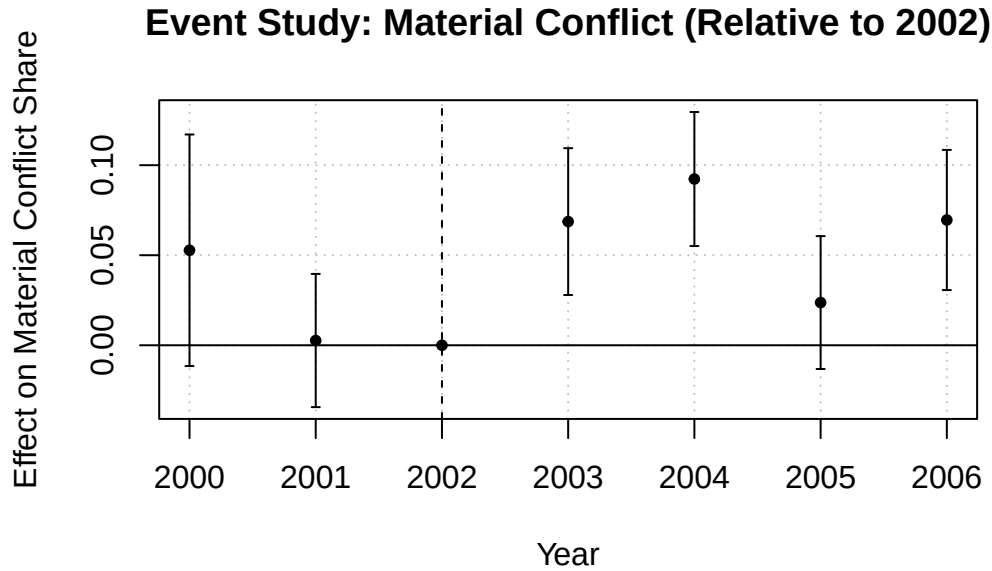
```
Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
baltic:post2004 0.01061 0.023296 0.455424 0.65179
... 2 variables were removed because of collinearity (baltic and
post2004)
---
Signif. codes: 0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1
RMSE: 0.047747 Adj. R2: 0.371855
Within R2: 9.798e-4
```

The post-2004 interaction term is small and statistically insignificant ($\beta = 0.011$, $SE = 0.023$, $p = 0.652$), indicating no detectable increase in Russia's share of verbal conflict toward the Baltic states following formal NATO accession. In contrast to the marginal anticipatory effect observed after the 2002 Prague Summit announcement, these findings suggest that rhetorical escalation, if present, was

concentrated during the negotiation phase rather than sustained after the implementation.

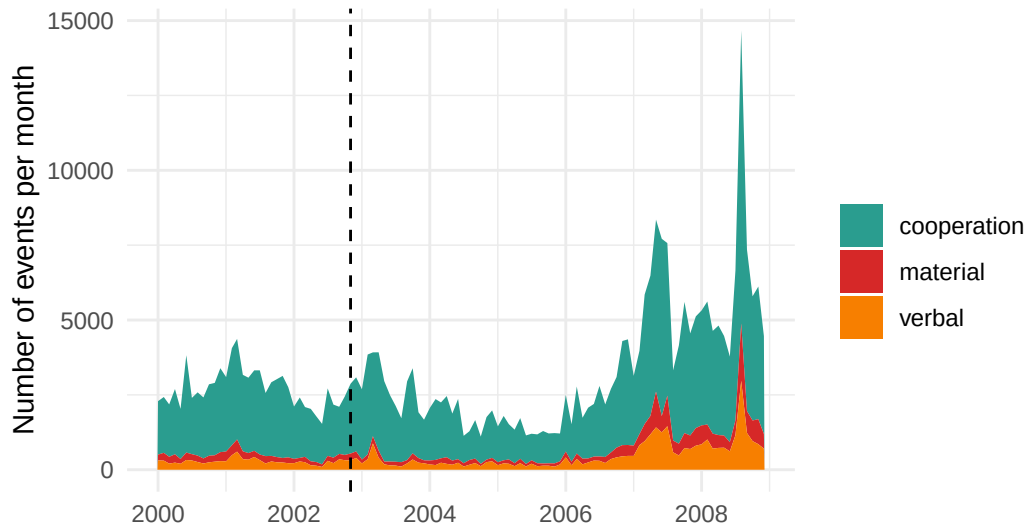


The following event study graph presents dynamic treatment effects relative to 2002. Pre-treatment coefficients (2000–2001) are statistically indistinguishable from zero, which supports the parallel trends assumption. Beginning in 2003, the Baltic states exhibit a positive and statistically meaningful increase in Russia’s verbal conflict share. The effect persists through 2005 before gradually declining towards 2006. Such a pattern suggests that Russia’s response to NATO enlargement was not immediate militarized escalation but more so sustained rhetorical signaling concentrated in the early accession period.



This figure presents dynamic treatment effects for material conflict between 2000 and 2006, using 2002 as the reference year. Pre-treatment coefficients (2000–2001) are statistically indistinguishable from zero, supporting the parallel trends assumption. Following the 2002 Prague Summit, shown by the dashed line, material conflict toward the Baltic states increases modestly in 2003 and peaks in 2004, before partially declining in 2005 and stabilizing in 2006 back to the levels seen in 2003. The magnitude of these effects is moderate and less pronounced than the corresponding verbal escalation. This pattern suggests limited hardening of behavior during the accession window but does not indicate a sharp or sustained material backlash. Rather than a decisive military escalation, the evidence points to a short-term period of tension accompanying NATO enlargement, alligning with classical signaling theory.

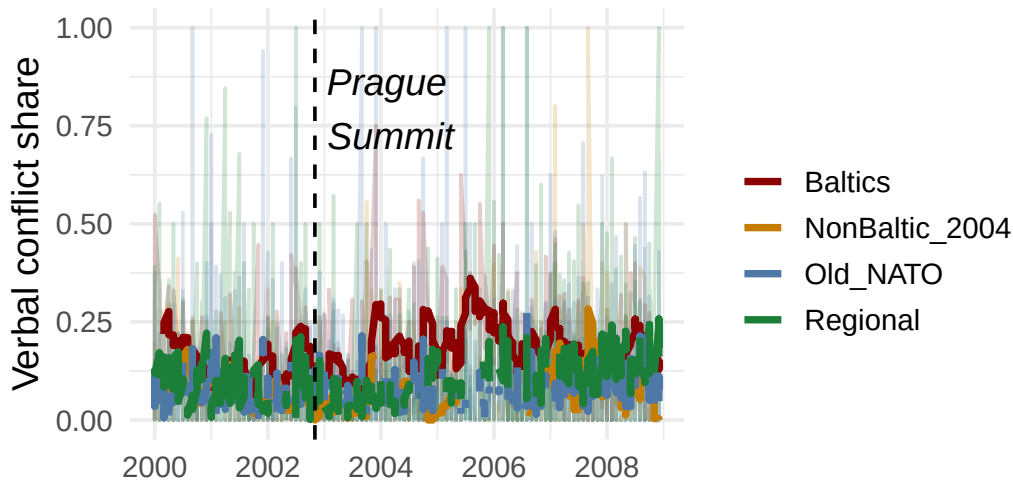
What Russia's interactions look like across all 34 countries GDELT 1.0, 2000–2008



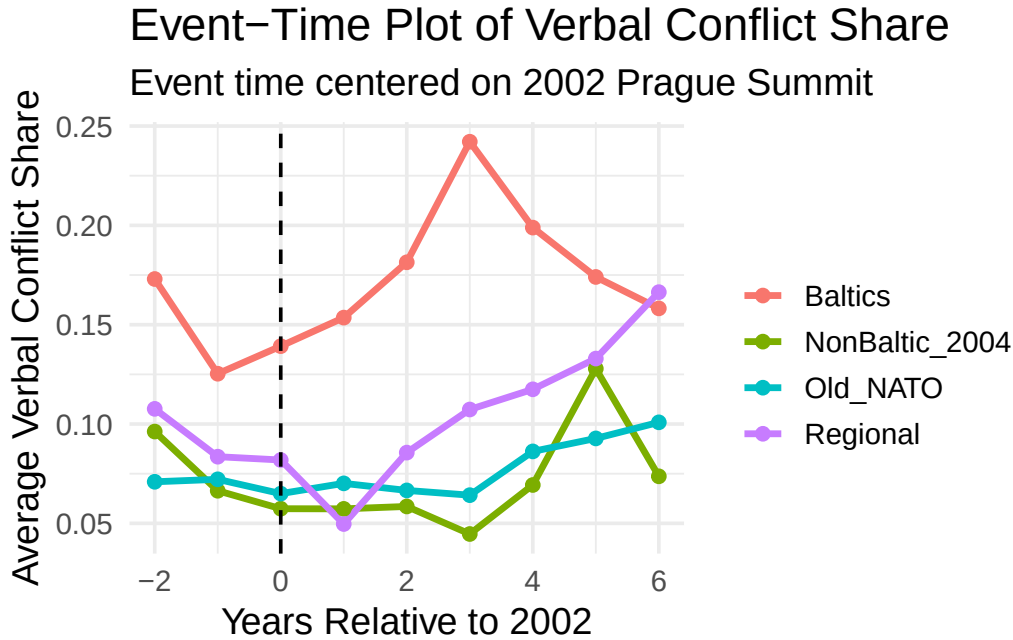
The following graph displays the monthly composition of Russia's interactions across all 34 countries between 2000 and 2008 by cooperation, verbal conflict, and material conflict. The dominant feature of the graph is the overwhelming presence of cooperative interactions, which consistently align with the cooperative period and events throughout the period. Verbal conflict constitutes a small but visible share, while material conflict remains a thin, constant layer across all years. There appears to be no clear structural break in November 2002, the date of the Prague Summit, nor in March 2004, when accession occurred. The overall amount of interactions remains stable until the spike in 2008, coinciding with the Georgia war. Thus, this figure demonstrates that NATO enlargement did not generate a system-wide escalation in Russian external behavior. Any effect of enlargement must therefore be selective rather than global, motivating the group-level analysis that follows.

Verbal conflict share over time, by group

Bold lines = 8-month rolling average. Faint lines = raw n



This graph presents monthly verbal conflict share by group using an 8-month rolling average to smooth short-term volatility. The Baltic states consistently possess a higher baseline level of verbal conflict compared to the other groups throughout the period. However, there is no sharp discontinuity at the 2002 Prague Summit. Instead, difference becomes more visible after 2004, with the Baltic line rising more noticeably than other categories. The non-Baltic 2004 group remains comparatively flat, as do longstanding NATO members. This pattern suggests that Russia's rhetorical signaling was not uniformly directed at all countries involved in the NATO enlargement. Rather, the divergence is concentrated in the Baltic cases, implying that the geography, historical incorporation, and identity dynamics, discussed in Sections 2 and 3, may be more relevant explanatory factors than alliance expansion alone. The figure therefore challenges a simple structural realist account of uniform backlash.



The event-time plot provides the most clear diagnostic of treatment effects and pre-trends. In the two years prior to 2002, trends appear broadly parallel across groups, with no evidence of an upward trajectory in Baltic verbal conflict share compared to the others, supporting the plausibility of the parallel trends assumption within the difference-in-differences design. Following 2002, no immediate jump is observed either. However, beginning around event time +2, corresponding to when the countries invited in the Prague Summit officially joined NATO, the Baltic states exhibit a noticeable increase in verbal conflict share compared to other groups, peaking around +3 before gradually declining. Crucially, non-Baltic 2004 entrants do not exhibit a similar pattern. This key difference suggests that Russia’s rhetorical escalation was not a uniform response to NATO enlargement but was concentrated toward specific borderland states. The pattern is consistent with arguments emphasizing proximity, historical incorporation, and identity-based security concerns rather than purely institutional alliance expansion.

Discussion

Differences in Difference Estimates

Table 1 reports two-way fixed effects difference-in-differences estimates. Using 2002 as the treatment year, the interaction between Baltic states and the post-2002 period is positive and marginally significant ($\beta = 0.027$, $SE = 0.015$, $p = 0.085$), suggesting a 2.7 percentage point increase in the share of verbal conflict relative to the control group.

However, when defining treatment as post-2004 accession, the interaction term is small and statistically insignificant ($\beta = 0.011$, $SE = 0.023$, $p = 0.652$). This indicates no detectable increase in verbal hostility following formal NATO membership.

Descriptive Patterns

Figure 1 presents aggregate patterns of Russia's interactions across all 34 countries between 2000 and 2010. While overall event volumes fluctuate over time, there is no clear system-wide surge in hostility surrounding NATO expansion. This suggests that any effects of enlargement were not global but potentially concentrated among treated states.

Figure 2 represents verbal conflict shares by group. Baltic states exhibit modest increases in verbal conflict share following the 2002 Prague Summit, though differences remain relatively small in magnitude. Material conflict, by contrast, remains largely flat across groups.

The persistence of the effect through 2006 shown in the event study graph indicates that rhetorical hostility was not limited to a single announcement shock. Instead, it reflects a short- to medium-term adjustment period during which Russia signaled dissatisfaction with the changing security architecture in its near abroad. The absence of corresponding increases in material conflict reinforces the interpretation of signaling rather than coercive escalation.

Finally,

Dynamic Effects

Figure 3 presents event-study estimates relative to 2002. Pre-treatment coefficients (2000–2001) are statistically indistinguishable from zero, supporting the parallel trends assumption. Post-2002 effects

are modest and short-lived, with no sustained escalation after 2004. These results suggest limited anticipatory signaling rather than durable rhetorical backlash.

Conclusion

This study evaluates whether NATO's enlargement including the Baltic states provoked escalatory responses from Russia. The evidence provides limited support for a narrative of strong backlash. While verbal conflict increased steadily following the 2002 Prague Summit and remained elevated through 2006, there is no evidence of a substantial or permanent escalation following formal accession in 2004. Material conflict patterns are weaker and less sharply tied to the enlargement milestones of the Prague Summit and the formal entry in 2004.

These findings suggest that Russia's response to Baltic accession was primarily rhetorical and strategic rather than militarized. Consistent with signaling theory, Moscow appears to have used diplomatic and informational channels to express dissatisfaction with the shifting power dynamics, without translating these signals into sustained coercive escalation. The results therefore challenge interpretations of enlargement as an immediate trigger of aggressive confrontation and instead point toward controlled and verbal resistance.

The findings additionally highlight the importance of distinguishing between rhetorical signaling and material escalation when evaluating alliance expansion and security dilemmas. NATO enlargement may generate tension, but the form and intensity of that response depend on strategic incentives and broader geopolitical conditions.

AI Transparency Statement

AI was used to resolve syntactical errors in R code. This primarily concerned the specification of regression models and the formatting of graphical output. The role of AI was limited to correcting technical implementation issues, ensuring that the code in graphs and models was executed properly. All substantive decisions regarding model choice, robustness checks, coding strategy, and interpretation of results were determined by the author.

The intellectual contribution of this paper, including its theoretical framing, methodological design,

and empirical analysis, rests with the author. AI assistance was confined to technical functions. I remain solely responsible for the scholarly content, interpretation of findings, and framing the contribution to the literature.

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